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I think there is a genuinely promising agenda here—but the four pieces should form a sequence, not be forced into one model:

questions → insight → theory → plan → collective action → value creation and capture

The TBV has developed the middle of that sequence much faster than either end. It argues that theories shape perception, search, experimentation, and action. Recent formal work then examines how managers evaluate and test already-articulated theories. But the pivotal transition from prior understanding to a genuinely new theory remains largely assumed. Indeed, Camuffo, Gambardella, and Pignataro explicitly acknowledge that their model does not explain how managers identify and combine the attributes and causal links from which theories are constructed; they also assume the identity of decision maker and firm. Those are precisely the two openings supplied by your materials. Their paper ↗

My strongest initial judgment is this:

The first paper should formalize the pre-Bayesian generation of strategic theories through questions and insight.

Not value capture. Not yet collective intentionality. And not an omnibus theory of managerial cognition. The central question should be:

How can a manager rationally direct inquiry toward a strategic theory that she cannot yet conceive?

That is a real problem. Bayesian reasoning can evaluate and update beliefs over possibilities already represented in the state space. It cannot explain how an unforeseen attribute, causal connection, action, or business model first becomes thinkable. Yet if theory generation is simply called “imagination” or treated as an exogenous spark, the TBV has relocated the source of strategic heterogeneity without explaining it.

The paper I presently see

A working title might be:

The Value of a Question: Directed Awareness and the Genesis of Strategic Theories

or, more provocatively:

Before Belief: A Pre-Bayesian Theory of Strategic Insight

The conceptual claim would be:

Managers do not generate theories by searching randomly through a fixed space of alternatives. Their existing understanding makes particular questions intelligible, salient, and apparently answerable. Asking one of those questions can produce an insight that expands the manager's awareness, changes the attributes and causal links she can represent, and thereby creates a new domain within which ordinary belief formation and Bayesian testing can begin.

This takes the best idea from the slide presentation and gives it an actual formal engine. It also uses the Wilkins paper in a disciplined way. The important import from Wilkins is not the entire social-ontology argument. It is the cognitional sequence:

- experience supplies the material;
- prior understanding makes a question possible;
- insight reorganizes the manager's conceptual space;
- judgment evaluates the resulting understanding;
- decision converts it into action.

That sequence supplies a much cleaner microfoundation for “generative rationality” than simply saying that managers imagine possible futures.

What the model could look like

The analyst represents an objective possibility structure, but the manager inhabits only a partial awareness space. At any awareness state:

1. The manager has a currently represented strategic problem, action set, and causal theory.
2. Her existing understanding makes a limited set of questions available. A question is not a signal about a fully specified state space; it is an awareness-expansion operation.
3. The manager does not know all the possible answers. Otherwise the answers are already conceptually represented and the problem has become Bayesian.
4. She nevertheless has a coarse, question-conditioned assessment of what answering the question might matter for—perhaps an imprecise payoff interval or an interval over the value of the actions that could become available.

5. She asks a question when resolving it could change her present strategic choice by enough to justify the cognitive or experimental cost.
6. An answer produces an insight: new attributes, causal links, actions, or questions enter awareness. Only then can the manager formulate probabilities, test hypotheses, and make a judgment.

This is where the C^+ machinery becomes useful. Its frontier-expansion procedure is already close to a formal theory of directed questioning. A frontier node becomes an intelligible but unresolved question; expanding it corresponds to inquiry; its children represent distinctions or causal possibilities that become available only after the insight.

But the appendix cannot simply be relabeled. Two changes are essential:

- Its exploration presently uncovers pieces of a fixed future decision tree. Strategic insight must sometimes reveal new descriptions, causal links, or actions—not merely more temporal detail.
- Its agent knows the correct objective payoff bounds on unseen continuations. In the TBV version, those bounds need to arise from prior understanding and may be imprecise or miscalibrated. Otherwise a referee will correctly say that omniscience has merely been hidden in the interval endpoints.

The proposition package

I would aim for three principal results and one extension.

1. Decision relevance of questions.

A question has strategic value only when some admissible answer could overturn the manager's current action ranking. Information volume is not the criterion. A narrow question capable of changing action can be more valuable than a highly informative question whose answers leave the same strategy optimal.

2. Understanding-induced heterogeneity.

Managers with the same preferences, the same observed data, and identical Bayesian competence can rationally develop different theories because their prior understandings make different questions available. Strategic heterogeneity therefore need not originate in different information, probabilistic beliefs, biases, resources, or random search. It can arise before probability enters the analysis.

3. Recursive insight and path dependence.

Answering one question can make previously unintelligible questions available. Consequently, the value of questions can be complementary, the

order of inquiry matters, and theory generation exhibits genuine path dependence. This would formalize the slide deck's central idea that insights reorganize understanding and open new possibility spaces.

4. Planning extension.

Once an insight produces an actionable theory, C^{Plan} converts that theory into a strategy by caching the selected causal path and its continuation assessment. This yields rational persistence: the manager need not reconstruct the entire theory at every decision point, but she can reopen it when anomalies or valuable off-plan questions justify the cost. Your existing confirmatory-depth result fits naturally here.

That last result creates a particularly useful distinction:

A theory describes a causal possibility; a strategy is a theory embodied in a plan.

The TBV often slides too quickly between “the firm’s theory” and “the firm’s strategy.” Your action-theoretic work gives you the apparatus to distinguish them.

Why I would not lead with value capture

You already have the conceptual ownership needed to return to value capture later. But a first paper centered on theories, awareness, and rents would now enter crowded territory. Ehrig and Zenger already combine the TBV, unawareness, and value capture to distinguish awareness, confidence, and resource rents. [Their 2024 paper ↗](#)

The new contribution cannot merely be that theories create awareness and awareness creates rents. That claim is taken.

Your stronger move is to endogenize where the awareness advantage comes from. Value capture then becomes a downstream paper:

Which firms capture the value created by strategic insight, especially when acting on or communicating the insight makes competitors and resource owners aware of it?

That could become a dynamic theory-formation race in which discovery, planning speed, disclosure, resource commitment, and competitive imitation jointly determine capture. But it should build on the pre-Bayesian foundation rather than carry the burden of establishing it.

Where Wilkins ultimately leads

The Wilkins paper points toward the second major project:

When Does a Manager's Theory Become the Firm's Strategy?

The TBV routinely speaks of a “firm's theory,” although theories originate in individual consciousness. The unresolved mechanism is not belief aggregation. It is collective intentionality: members deliberately relate themselves to the same object through a common plan and undertake complementary roles as though the organization were a single acting subject.

That produces a second powerful paper about the theory-bearing firm:

- hierarchy determines which theory receives organizational standing;
- a shared plan carries the theory across people and time;
- organizational culture preserves tacit background understanding;
- authority can enable coherent action before everyone independently understands or endorses the theory;
- excessive commitment can suppress questions that would generate a superior theory.

The current TBV recognizes that organizations privilege some theories and not others, but does not yet provide a formal account of how an individual theory becomes an organizationally persistent intentional structure. Felin and Zenger's foundational statement and the newer agenda both leave room here.

So my present agenda would be:

- 1. Genesis:** questions, insight, and pre-Bayesian awareness.
- 2. Embodiment:** theories become strategies through planning and rational commitment.
- 3. Collectivization:** plans become firm-level intentional structures.
- 4. Appropriation:** theory formation, disclosure, competition, and value capture.

My vote is to begin with **The Value of a Question** and allow C^{Plan} to appear as the final theory-to-strategy extension. The first paper should stop before attempting a full model of collective intentionality or value capture.

The choice I would like us to settle next is between these two claims:

- **Great strategies begin with questions that change what theories are conceivable.**
- **A theory becomes a strategy only when it is embodied in a plan that rationally constrains future deliberation.**

I think the first is the agenda-launching paper and the second is its natural sequel.